

HISTORY OF



SANTA BARBARA COUNTY,

CALIFORNIA,

WITH
ILLUSTRATIONS *AND* BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCHES
OF ITS
PROMINENT MEN AND PIONEERS.



OAKLAND, CAL.
THOMPSON & WEST.

1883.

Cattle were generally valued at \$8 per head, sheep \$3, and land at twenty-five cents per acre, and sometimes, in case of a widow, or a poor and deserving person, as low as ten cents per acre.

José de la Guerra y Noriega had the ranches:—

Conejo,	containing.....	53,280 acres
Simi,	"	108,000 "
Las Posas,	"	26,640 "
San Julian,	"	20,000 "
Salsipuedes,	"	35,200 "

CHAPTER XVII.

THE LOST WOMAN.

Statement of John Nidever—Removal of Indians in 1836—Signs of Life on the Island in 1851—Second Visit—Discovery of the Woman—Unexpected Welcome—In the Hunter's Camp—Removal to Santa Barbara—General Interest in the Woman—A Subject of Kindness—Her Death.

THE subject is a favorite with romancers, and has been *written up* so much that the public is greatly misinformed, and a plain statement of the facts, without any attempt to weave it into a romantic form, will be the most acceptable. The story begins with the removal of a number of Indian women from the Island of San Nicolas, in 1836. According to the best authorities, the Island of San Nicolas, as well as the others, were once thickly populated; in fact, the large piles of shells, bones, and other refuse prove the fact without other evidence. According to Nidever and others who hunted around here as early as 1835, the Alaska Indians were in the habit of making periodic visits to the islands for otter and other skins. They were a savage race, and made fierce attacks against all who attempted otter hunting on any of the islands. They were supplied with fire-arms, and were dangerous foes even to the white man, and much more so to the natives who had only stone implements of warfare. In 1836 a company of these Indians who were left on the islands by a Russian vessel, chased Nidever and his party to their landing, and were only repelled by a sharp fire which killed several of their men. The chase was on the water in boats, and the contest was in trying to prevent them from landing at the only practicable place. According to the best authorities, a party of these Indians took possession of San Nicolas Island for the purpose of hunting otter, and finally took possession of the women, and slew every man and male child on the island, in the quarrel that ensued. When the Indians abandoned the island, after the hunt was over, they left the women to their fate. It was some years subsequent to this that the padres employed Sparks and the others to remove the survivors. Recent investigations in the remains on the islands place the former inhabitants among the Toltecs or Aztecs, and hence the white skin and pleasant manners of the wild woman. The following account is

mostly compiled from notes furnished by Dr. Dimmick, of Santa Barbara:—

STATEMENT OF JOHN NIDEVER.

I arrived on the coast in the year 1834, in the month of November. In the early part of the following year (1835), I came to Santa Barbara, and engaged in otter hunting, which I have followed almost uninterruptedly until within a few years. At the beginning of 1835, Isaac J. Sparks and Luis T. Burton,* Americans, also otter hunters, settled here, and chartered the schooner *Peor es Nada* (worse than nothing) for a trip to the Lower California coast. The schooner was commanded by Charles Hubbard, who was hired by the owner of the schooner, a Spaniard at Monterey. The crew placed in her by Sparks and Burton was, with two or three exceptions, composed of Kanakas. The *Peor es Nada* left Santa Barbara about the latter part of April, 1835. About three months after, she returned to San Pedro, and from there went directly to the Island of San Nicolas for the purpose of taking off the Indians then living there. Sparks, who hunted with me for several years afterwards, told about removing the Indians, but I cannot now recollect who authorized or caused their removal. I remember distinctly, however, that a man by the name of Williams, a former acquaintance of mine in the Rocky Mountains, was an interested party, as he assisted in their removal. I am under the impression also that another man in Los Angeles took an active part in the affair. The circumstances of leaving the Indian woman alone upon the Island were, as near as I can recollect, from what Sparks told me, as follows:—

REMOVAL OF THE INDIANS.

Having got all the Indians together on the beach ready for embarking, one of them made signs that her child had been left behind, whereupon she was allowed to go back and fetch it. She was gone some time, when a strong wind springing up, they did not dare to wait longer for her, fearing for the safety of the schooner.

The water, which is quite shoal about the island, becomes exceedingly rough in a storm, and there is no harbor of any kind that would afford shelter in a heavy gale. They ran before the wind, and reached San Pedro in safety. Here the Indians were put ashore, some being taken to Los Angeles, and some to the Mission of San Gabriel. It was the intention of the captain of the schooner to return for the woman who had been left on the island, as soon as possible. From San Pedro the *Peor es Nada* came direct to Santa Barbara, took Sparks and me over to the Santa Rosa Island, and then sailed for Monterey where she had been ordered, to take a cargo of lumber to San Francisco. At the entrance to the Golden Gate the *Peor es Nada* capsized, and her crew

* Burton spelled his first name Lewis; the Spanish Luis. The Spanish changed the spelling of many names: Albert to Alberto; Alfred to Alfredo, etc.

were washed ashore. It was afterwards reported that the schooner drifted out to sea, and was picked up by a Russian vessel, though the report was never confirmed. There were now no craft of any kind larger than the Indian canoe, and the boats of the otter hunters left on the coast, and none cared to attempt the passage of the channel in an open boat. It was soon known throughout the coast that an Indian woman had been left on the island, but so far as I can learn, no attempt was ever made to rescue her. As years passed by, all thought she had perished.

SIGNS OF LIFE ON THE ISLAND.

In 1851 I had occasion to visit the San Nicolas. I found signs that led me to believe that the woman still survived, or that a human being was living upon the island. I had with me a man named Tom Jeffries. He and I with one of the Indians landed near the lower end of the island and walked along the beach, and on the bank close to the beach for a distance of five or six miles. Soon after starting out we found the foot-prints of a human being, that, in all probability, had been made during the previous rainy season. They were sunk quite deep in the ground, that was now quite dry and hard. They were distinctly defined, and from their size we concluded that they were those of a woman. We also discovered three small circular inclosures, about two hundred yards back from the beach, something like a mile apart and situated on slightly rising ground. They were circular in shape, six or seven feet in diameter, with walls, perhaps five or six feet high, made of brush. Near the huts or inclosures, there were stakes of drift-wood stuck in the ground, and suspended upon them, at a height of five or six feet, were pieces of dried blubber, which had the appearance of having been placed there within a month or two, as they were still in a good state of preservation. With these exceptions there was nothing about the inclosures, or, as I call them, wind-breaks, that indicated that they had been occupied for years. We had come ashore early in the morning, and, after finding the foot-prints and wind-breaks, we intended to make further search, but before noon a strong wind sprung up, and we hastened back to the schooner. We were hardly on board when the wind increased to a gale and continued to blow for about eight days, so strong at times that we expected to be blown out to sea. We were on the south side of the island, or under its lee, and in a measure protected from the wind, but the sea was so rough that we found it almost impossible to remain at anchor. Once our anchor dragged and we were compelled to improvise a second one by filling a bag with stones. The eighth day the wind having gone down, we were enabled to leave the island.

SECOND VISIT.

In the winter of 1852 I made a second trip to the island for otter, having seen large numbers on my

previous trip. On this trip I was accompanied by Charles Brown. We landed, as on our former visit, at the lower end of the island. We took two Indians ashore with us and left them in charge of the boat, while Brown and I walked along the beach, or on the top of the bank when we could not get down to the beach, towards the head of the island. We went partly to see where the otter lay, and partly to see if we could find any signs of the Indian woman, as Father Gonzales, to whom we had reported the discoveries made on our former visit, assured us there was no longer any doubt of her being alive. We had decided to go to the head of the island, as, for various reasons, we concluded that if alive she would be most likely to be found there. The water is better and more abundant there, and it is a better place for both fish and seal. We visited the huts that Jeffries had discovered and found them and their surroundings unchanged, except that it seemed to me that the seal blubber, which I had seen on my former visit, had been removed and fresh blubber hung in its place. In the neighborhood of the huts near the shore we saw seven or eight wild dogs. They were about the size and form of a coyote, of a black and white color. I have seen the same kind of dogs among the Northwest Indians. They were very wild and ran off as soon as they saw us. When within about a half a mile of the head of the island, we struck a low, sandy flat that extended from one side of the island to the other. Here we thought she must, in all probability, be living, as the ground both to the north and east of this flat was high and exposed to the wind. After searching around for some time and finding no signs of her, we were about to return, having concluded that the dogs must have eaten her, as not even her bones were to be found, when I discovered in the crotch of a bush or small tree a basket, and upon throwing off the piece of seal skin that covered it, we found within carefully laid together, a dress made of shag skins cut in square pieces, a rope made of sinew, and several smaller articles, such as abalone fish-hooks, bone needles, etc. After examining them Brown proposed replacing them and returning the basket to the tree where we found it, but I scattered them about on the ground, telling him that if upon our return we should find them replaced in the basket it would be positive proof of the woman's existence. As it was now quite late we returned to the schooner, intending to renew the search at the first opportunity, as the extreme head of the island was still unexplored by us. For the next few days, however, we were busy hunting otters, and about the fourth or fifth day a southeast wind began to blow, which soon increased to a gale. We waited about six or seven days for it to go down and then with some difficulty we ran over to the San Miguel Island.

DISCOVERY OF THE WOMAN.

I next fitted out for a hunt on the San Nicolas in

July, 1853. My crew consisted of Charles Brown, one Irishman and four Mission Indians. This time I went with the intention of making a thorough search for the missing woman. We arrived off the island in the early part of the day and anchored opposite the middle on the northeast side about 10 A. M. Brown and I went on shore to see where the otter lay and to select a suitable camping place. We left two of our Indians in charge of the boat. We then kept along near the shore without finding any signs of the Indian woman, until we reached the head of the island. Here I sat down to rest while Brown went around the head and down some distance on the other side. When he returned he told me he had seen fresh tracks of the Indian woman and had followed them from the beach up over the bank, but on the side of the ridge which formed the head of the island he had lost them, the ground being covered with moss. I was at first disposed to think that our men from the schooner had gone over there, but a moment's reflection convinced me that it would be impossible for them to get in advance of us, and, besides, Brown said the tracks were too small to have been made by either of our men. It was now getting late and we returned on board with the determination of making the next day a thorough exploration of the upper portion of the island. Accordingly, after breakfast the next morning we started with all of our men excepting the cook. Reaching the low, sandy flat, before mentioned, Brown and the four men stretched out in a line and crossed to the other side of the island, while I continued along near the shore, on the same side I had come, towards the head of the island. Brown and his men made no discoveries in passing over the island. He then sent the men back to search along the borders of the sandy flat, and among the bushes where the basket had been found. He went up towards the head on that side until he struck the track he had seen the night before. He followed it up again until it was lost in the moss, and then continued up the side of the ridge until he found a short piece of drift-wood. From this he concluded that she had been down to the beach for fire-wood, and had dropped this piece on her way up. From this point he saw further up the ridge three huts. Upon reaching them he found them made of whale ribs, covered with brush, although they were now open on all sides. The grass was quite high within them, showing that no one had occupied them for some time. He was now on one of the highest parts of the ridge, and he began to look about in all directions. The sandy flat was in plain sight and he could see most of the men. At last his eye caught sight of a small, black object a long distance off that seemed to be moving. It looked at first very much like a crow. Walking toward it he soon saw that it was the Indian woman. She was seated in an inclosure similar to those already described, so that her head and shoulders were

barely visible above it. As he approached her two or three dogs, like those we had seen before, that were close to her, began growling. Without looking in the direction of Brown, she gave a yell and the dogs disappeared. Brown had halted within a few yards of her, and at once began to signal to the men by placing a hat on the ramrod of his gun and raising and lowering it. He soon succeeded in attracting their attention and they came towards him. In the meantime Brown had an opportunity of observing the woman. She was seated cross-legged on some grass that covered the ground within the inclosure, and which no doubt served as a bed. Her only dress was a kind of gown, leaving her neck and shoulders bare, and long enough, when she stood up, to reach her ankles. It was made of shag skins cut in squares and sewed together, the feathers pointing downwards. Her head had no cover save a thick mass of matted hair of a yellowish-brown color, probably from exposure to sun and weather, and which looked as if it had rotted off. She was engaged in stripping the blubber from a piece of seal skin, which she held across one knee, using in the operation a rude knife made of a piece of iron hoop. Within the inclosure was a smouldering fire, and without a large pile of ashes and another of bones, which would indicate that this had been her abode for a long time. From the time Brown first arrived within hearing distance she kept up a continual talking to herself, occasionally shading her eyes with her hand and gazing steadily at the men who were seen walking around on the flat below. She was evidently much interested in their movements. As the men came near, Brown motioned them to spread out so as to prevent her escape if she was so disposed. Just before the men reached her camp, Brown, who had not yet been seen by her, came around in front.

UNEXPECTED WELCOME.

To his great surprise she received him with much dignity and politeness, bowing and smiling with ease and self-possession. As fast as the men came up she greeted them in the same way. The men seated themselves on the ground around, the woman all the time talking, although not a word of hers could be understood, although our Indians spoke several dialects. From a sack or bag made of grass she took some roots, known among the Californians as the *carcomites*, and another root whose name I did not learn, and placed them in the fire. When they were roasted she offered them to us to eat. We found them very palatable, indeed. We were now desirous of taking her on board the schooner. We did not apprehend that she would attempt to escape, as she seemed much pleased with our company. We commenced making signs for her to go with us, but she seemed unable to comprehend them until we intimated that she must gather up all her food, when she set about the work with the greatest alacrity, and commenced putting them in a large basket, such

as is in general use among the Indians of this coast. She had considerable dried blubber of the seal and sea elephant. This was all carefully collected. There was also a seal's head, in such a decayed condition that the brains were oozing out. At her desire this was also taken along. She seemed desirous of preserving everything that would sustain life, thus indicating the sad experiences of her eighteen years of solitude. When all was ready she took a burning stick in one hand and left her camp. Each of us had a portion of her household goods in our hands or on our shoulders. She trotted merrily along, and led us to a spring of good water, which came out under a shelving rock near the beach. Here we found a store of bones in the clefts of the rocks. It would seem that in time of scarcity she would come here and suck the bones as long as any nutriment could be obtained from them. Here, also, were pieces of dried blubber hung on stakes, above the reach of the foxes and dogs which inhabited the island. We gained the woman's confidence by taking care to preserve all these articles. On the way to the schooner she led us past another spring, which she seemed to have used for bathing, as she stopped and washed her hands and face. This spring was not far from the landing. When we reached the boat we made motions for her to step in, which she did, kneeling down in the bow, holding to the sides with her hands. When we got on the vessel she sought the vicinity of the stove, keeping as near to it as possible, which act indicated more of her bitter experience on the island. We offered her some of our food, which she ate with relish; in fact, from this time she appeared to prefer our style of food to her own. Brown went to work that afternoon and made her a skirt or petticoat out of some bed-ticking, with which she was much pleased, continually calling our attention to it. This skirt, with a man's shirt and neck-tie, constituted her new wardrobe. While Brown was sewing she made signs that she wished to sew, and Brown gave her a needle and thread. She did not know how to put the thread through the eye. After this was done by one of us she knew how to use it. I gave her an old cloak or heavy cape, which was much torn and dilapidated. She very patiently sewed up all the rents, and made it quite serviceable in the cold, windy weather, which prevailed occasionally. In sewing she thrust the needle into the cloth with her right hand and pulled it through, drawing the thread tight with her left hand.

IN THE HUNTER'S CAMP.

The following day we moved on shore, and made a camp on a narrow piece of ground between the beach and the rocks, and made a shelter by leaning some poles against the rocks and covering them with sail cloth. We made a similar shelter for her at a short distance, covering it with brush. We remained on the island hunting otter about a month. During

this time she evinced no disposition to leave, but was generally talking, singing, and wandering about the island. She assisted in the camp work, bringing wood and water when it was needed. Her vessels for carrying water were quite unique. They were woven of grass, shaped somewhat like a demijohn, except they had wider mouths, and were lined with a thin coating of asphaltum. The process of lining them was rather ingenious. She put several pieces of the asphaltum, which is found in great quantity along the beach, in the bottom of the basket, and then on the top of them some hot pebbles. When the asphaltum was melted, by a quick, rotary motion, she would cover the inside of the basket with an even coating, after which the surplus, with the rocks, was thrown out. These baskets were water-tight, and would last a long time. She had several of these baskets in process of construction when we found her. She would work at one a few minutes, abandon it, and try another. I am not aware that she ever completed one when with us. When we killed otters we usually, after skinning them, threw the bodies into the sea. One day we killed a large female which was with young. When about to cast it into the sea, as usual, she, in her mute way, protested. The young one, which was nearly grown and covered with fur, was taken out and the skin stuffed by one of the party and made to look quite natural. She took a great fancy to the young otter, and suspending it to a pole of her shelter would swing it backwards and forwards for hours, talking to it in a kind of sing-song tone. The carcass of the mother seal becoming putrid in a day, she made no objections to its removal.

REMOVAL TO SANTA BARBARA.

After hunting successfully for about a month, we put everything on the schooner and sailed for Santa Barbara. Not long after sailing, a furious gale arose, which threatened to engulf the little vessel. She made signs that she could allay the wind, and kneeling down, facing the quarter from whence the wind blew, she commenced making incantations or prayers, which she continued for some time, and at intervals during the storm. When the wind abated, she pointed in triumph to the patch of clear sky, as much as to say, "See what I did!" We approached the shore early in the morning. It was evident that she had never seen it before, or any of the ordinary sights of a settlement. An ox-team, with a Spanish cart, passed on the sand. It is doubtful whether pleasure or wonder predominated in her mind. The yoke which tied the animals to each other and to the cart; the uncouth wheels, with their rotary motion, which she imitated with curious gestures, were inexpressibly wonderful, delightful, and ludicrous. She laughed, talked, and gesticulated all at once. After landing, a horseman, among others, came to the beach. This was a new creature, but she had the courage to examine it, touching horse

and man in succession. She turned to her friends, for so may be considered her captors, and straddled the first two fingers of her right hand over her left thumb, and imitating the galloping of a horse with her fingers, gave a shout of delight. She was taken to Nidever's house and cared for by his wife.

GENERAL INTEREST IN THE WOMAN.

The story soon spread that the lost woman of the San Nicolas was found. The possibility of there being a woman living alone on a desert island in the ocean, with only wild animals for companions, had been discussed in many households, and with such warm-hearted people was a subject of intense interest. As the years had passed, and nothing was heard of her, the general conclusion was that she had perished, probably devoured by the wild dogs. The fathers of the mission had exerted themselves in the matter, and had offered a reward of \$200 for information that would lead to her recovery. When Nidever reported finding tracks on the island, and other evidences of life, Father Gonzales had confidently asserted she was alive, and the interest in the matter became intense.

Hundreds flocked to Nidever's house. Among others came Fathers Gonzales, Sanchez, and Jimeno. Though familiar with all the dialects of the coast, not a word of her language could they understand. Indians from Santa Ynez, Los Angeles, and other places, were brought, with no better success; not one of them understood a word of her language. She soon became very expert in conversing by signs, however, and continued to tell portions of her story, so that but little uncertainty attended the narrative. She relates that when she went back after her child she wandered a long time without finding it; that when she concluded that the dogs had eaten the child, she lay down and cried a long time and became sick, could not eat anything, and got so weak that she could not walk; that she recovered so she could get around, and began to eat. She had often seen vessels on the sea, but none of them ever came to take her away. She finally became reconciled to her fate, and commenced the routine of life which was to be varied only by hunger, thirst, cold, and fear of wild animals for near a score of years.

A SUBJECT OF KINDNESS.

She was received with the utmost kindness. Almost every one made her a present of money, clothing, or trinkets, which, however, she would immediately give to her friends, or to the children who came to see her. In those days the Panama steamers used to touch at Santa Barbara, and all the passengers were desirous of seeing the lost woman. She would often put on her finest dress of feathers and go through some movements which the people termed dancing, though it had little resemblance to the graceful movements of a ball-room. She became very much attached to the family, which, however,

was mutual, for Mr. Nidever several times refused large sums which were offered him to have her exhibited to the public at San Francisco.

She was estimated to be about fifty years old at the time she was recovered. As near as could be made out from her signs, she had, at the time of her being left on the island, two children, one of which was a nursing babe, the other some years older, though in the opinion of some, the elder child had died some time previous. She had a smooth face, though the skin on her body and limbs was much wrinkled. It was but a short time before her death that they succeeded in making her understand their desire to have some words of her own language. The following are about all that were learned of it: A hide she called "tocah;" man, "nache;" the sky, "toygwah;" the body, "puoo-chay."

HER DEATH.

She was like a child in every respect, with no control over her appetite. She was excessively fond of fruit, which she would eat at all hazards. It produced a dysentery, which, in spite of careful nursing and attendance, terminated fatally in about four weeks. During her sickness it was thought that a diet of seal's meat, such as she had been accustomed to, would relieve her. Some was procured and roasted, but she shook her head and laughed, and rubbed her finger along her worn-out teeth, signifying that they were too old. She was buried by the fathers, and the most of her trinkets, including the best feather dress, taken to Rome.

The thoughtful reader will be apt to make a mental inquiry as to the secret of her having kept her heart warm through the long solitude, for that she had the warm love, gratitude, and affection of a child, none who knew her will deny. They will also ask why the *other dress*? Was it made and kept for eighteen years in readiness for the visit of the man who never came? The answer may possibly be found in the ever mysterious realms of woman's nature.

The story of the lost woman will be a subject of wonder and romance as long as history is read.

CHAPTER XVIII.

OPERATIONS OF THE COUNTY GOVERNMENT.

Operations of the County Government—Qualifications for Office—Conscious Greatness—Court at La Graciosa—Lawless Element Among the Americans—County Jail—Roads—First Board of Supervisors—Establishment of the First Newspaper—The *Gazette*—Military Company—Discovery of Gold Mines—Notice—City Government—Indian Affairs—Big Storm—School Matters in 1856—Delinquent Taxes—County Treasurer in Trouble—Trouble for the *Gazette*—Problem in Ethnology—Funny Jury—Banditti—Light-House—City Improvements Called For.

THE whole American policy of jurisprudence rests on the supposition that the masses of the people are, to some extent at least, acquainted not only with the